EGM, Mistry became feisty. The same day, he issued a statement titled ‘Ratan Tata takes credit, Cyrus Mistry shares credit’. In the release, Mistry tried to impress upon the shareholders of the companies, that would be holding EGMs soon that he had played a significant role in the success of TCS and JLR and to clear the wrong impression that he was a ‘hands off’ chairman and had little to do with the software giant and the UK marquee car maker. In the case of the former, he said that he had contributed immensely by meeting ‘global CEOs, some along with TCS leadership’, ‘engaged with employees at TCS centres’, amongst others. About JLR, he said that it was Ralph Speth and Ravi Kant who made the acquisition, and he contributed by taking ‘design reviews’ and met dealers in ‘China, USA, and India’.

In a section titled, ‘One man’s ego versus an institution’, he accused Ratan of having tried hard to persuade JRD to sell off TCS to IBM, with which TIL was in talks for a JV when Ratan was the chairman of the latter. His imputation was that if Ratan had had his way, the jewel of the Tata crown would have been lost to the group. He asserted that it was F.C. Kohli who scuppered Ratan’s plan and saved the day by stoutly opposing it. The statement added that ‘JRD Tata turned down the offer, demonstrating true vision. But, it was also a near-death experience for TCS at the hands of Mr Ratan Tata.’ Here, Mistry had made a big mistake. He was factually incorrect.

The next day, Kohli in a statement refuted Mistry’s allegation. He said that he ‘would like to reiterate that at no point at that time was there ever an intention of the Tata group to sell TCS to IBM’. Mistry tried to save face by shifting blame, stating that the information was purportedly received from a source close to JRD. Trying to soften the impact of the faux pas, he made a statement stating that the source had ‘informed him that it was Ratan Tata’s intention, and not the group’s intention, to sell TCS’.

The twenty-fifth of November was an important day for Tata Steel. It was the third board meeting of the company since Mistry’s replacement. By now, support for Ratan had become overwhelming. ‘The unions at Jamshedpur were very clear on who they would support. There was no question [of] whether they liked Mistry or not. It did not matter. Many of the employees at Jamshedpur are fifth and sixth generation in the steel company and are there because of the Tatas,’ says Narendran.